

Section 4.5: The difference between the Internet and the Intranet

The **internet** and the **intranet** are two very different things.

In this section we discuss the **differences** between the two including their respective **purposes** and **uses**.

Key Concepts of this section:

- # Understand the **difference** between the **internet** and an **intranet**.
- # Know the **uses** of the **internet** and an **intranet**.
- # Be able to **compare** the **internet** to an **intranet** in terms of what they are **used** for.

Internet and intranet

There are **two** main types of **network environments**. These are listed below:

- [Internet](#)
- [Intranet](#).

Each of these have their own **purposes** and **uses** and we will discuss both of these in detail below.

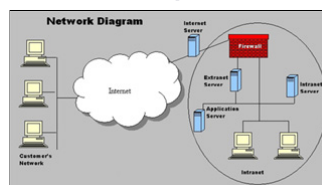
We will also [compare](#) the two of them in terms of how their **purposes** **differ** from each other.



Key Words:

Internet, Intranet.

Examples:



The internet and an intranet.

1 Internet

What is the internet?

The internet is a huge **collection** of **computers** and **networks** that have been **joined together**.

Remember:

The internet is the **world's largest WAN** (wide area network) and it is getting bigger all the time as more and more people connect their devices to it.

When you connect your device/computer to the internet, you can potentially **access** and **share** data from other computers that are connected.

The internet started off as a **military project** in the 1960's called '**ARPANet**'.

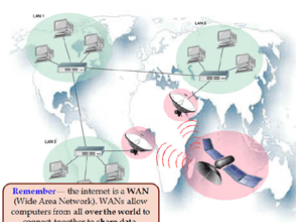
ARPANet was initially designed to connect **4 powerful computers** so that researchers had access to them all.

Over the years more and more computers connected to ARPANet until it eventually became the internet that we know today.

Note:

As of February 2016, there are **3.3 billion** devices and computers connected to the internet. Click [here](#) for up-to-date internet usage stats.

Examples:



Remember - the internet is a WAN (Wide Area Network). WANs allow computers from all over the world to connect together to share data.

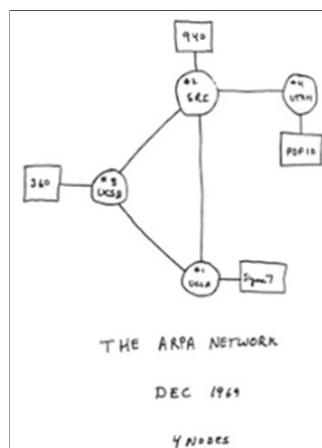
The internet is a huge collection of computers and devices that have been joined together all over the world. (click to zoom)

What is the internet used for?

Because there are so many computers connected to the internet, it is literally the largest source of **shared information** in the world.

The list below highlights this and some other uses of the internet:

- Browsing **web pages** using the World Wide Web (**www**)
- Sending and receiving **emails**
- **Sharing** files and information
- **Video Conferencing** (face to face discussion using a web cam)
- **Voice calls** (like Skype)
- Streaming **music** and **video**
- Online **banking**
- **E-Commerce** (buying/selling goods online)
- **Advertising**
- **Blogging**
- **Social media**
- Playing multi-player **online games**.



Hand-drawn plan of ARPANet showing how the four computers were to be connected.

The internet allows us to do all of the above list across **vast distances**.

For example: You can send an **email** to someone in a **different country**.

How do you connect to the internet?

To **access** the internet you need several things:

- A **computer** or **device** (such as a tablet or a mobile phone)
- A **router** or a modem (to send digital data over the telephone network)
- An **ISP** (internet service provider).

Note:

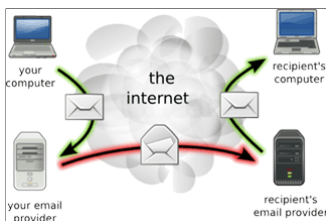
Mobile phones or tablets don't necessarily need a router as you could access the internet using a paid **data plan**.

Internet Service Providers (ISP) are companies that provide users with **access** to the internet, usually for a monthly or annual fee.

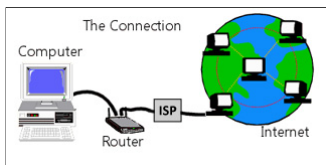
Once you have paid your fee to the ISP, you would be given a **username** and **password** which you can use to **connect** to the internet.

Here in Bermuda, internet service providers include Logic and CableVision.

Notice how it is dated 1969. Did you think the internet was that old?



One use of the internet is to send emails from one location to another.



To connect to the internet you need a computer, a router/modem and an internet service provider (ISP).

ISP's provide you with a login and password so you can connect to the internet.

2 Intranets

What is an intranet?

Intranets are like a **private internet**. They function in a similar way to the internet but are only accessible by users of the intranet (outsiders cannot connect).

Intranets exist only within the **building** or the **company** and users need a **login id** and **password** before they can join.

What are intranets used for?

Intranets offer **similar features** to the internet such as:

- Viewing **web pages**
- Sending **emails**
- **Sharing** files and information
- etc.

Schools often make use of intranets to provide information to students.

This information could include:

- Learning **resources**
- Course information
- **Homework** schedules
- etc.

Only students in the school that own the intranet would be able to access this information. Everyone else is **locked out**.

How do you connect to an intranet?

Anyone with the right to use an intranet would be given a **login id** and **password**.

Anyone without the correct login details would be **unable** to connect.

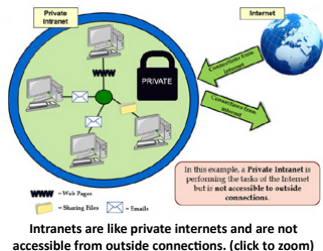
You would also normally have to be **physically within** the **building** where the intranet exists in order to use it (**inside the school or business premises for example**).

Login id's can also be used to **restrict** users from accessing certain parts of the intranet.

For example:

Students could be given access to **course information** and **homework schedules** only and **teachers** could be given access to **everything** on the intranet.

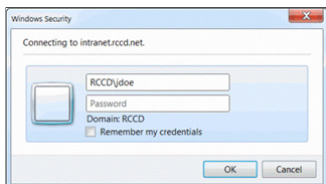
Examples:



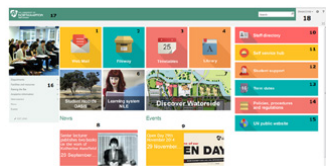
Intranets are like private internets and are not accessible from outside connections. (click to zoom)



An intranet is private and only exists within the premises of an organisation such as a school.



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An example of a school intranet. It contains information that is relevant to the people using it. (click to zoom)

Comparing the internet and intranet

The table below **summarises** the **differences** between the internet and an intranet in terms of their **purpose** and **how** they are used:

Internet	Intranet
The term ' Internet ' comes from the phrase International Network .	The term ' Intranet ' comes from the phrase Internal Restricted Access Network .
The internet is used to share data globally .	Intranets are used to share data locally and privately .
The internet is used to provide information that is relevant to a wide range of people.	Intranets are used to provide information which is relevant to a single company or organisation .
The internet can be accessed from anywhere as long as you have an internet connection.	Intranets can only be accessed from within the company or organisation that owns it.

Examples:



The internet allows users to share information globally.



Intranets allow users to share data with a room or building.

Activity!

[Differences between the internet and intranet - Research Sheet](#)

Click the above task and answer the questions about the differences between intranets and the internet.

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